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**ALIEN ENEMY M68-279:
The Unresolved Case of Vincenzo Beltrone**

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Ten minutes before midnight on December 8, 1941, some 30 hours after the Japanese surprise attack on Pearl Harbor, FBI agents arrested Vincenzo Nicola Ostilio Beltrone—poet, journalist, artist and photographer—in his Greenwich Village studio, charging him as an enemy alien suspected of supporting the fascist government of Italy.

By 2:00 am, Beltrone, native son of Stignano, Calabria, and United States resident for 34 years, was officially a prisoner of the United States government.

Although not the only Italian American who was imprisoned during World War II, Beltrone was one of the first to be arrested and one of the last to be released. By December 10, 1941, FBI Director J. Edgar Hoover had arrested some 147 Italians, a small number when compared to the 857 Germans and 1,291 Japanese who had also been taken into custody. By February 1942, there were 264 Italians in custody, with the number rising throughout the early war years.

Only a few hours before the arrest of Vincenzo Beltrone and several hundred other Italian Americans, Edward Ennis, chief counsel for the Immigration and Naturalization Service, succeeded in convincing President Franklin Roosevelt to sign Proclamation 2527, which extended the regulations against Japanese aliens to include Italian aliens. The new proclamation gave the federal government the authority to detain enemy aliens and to confiscate their property. It also permitted immediate and summary apprehension of “alien enemies deemed dangerous to the public health or safety of the United States by the Attorney General or the Secretary of War.”

Actually, however, the midnight roundups that took place in early December 1941 had been planned long before the bombing of Pearl Harbor. The FBI began drawing up lists of those to be arrested as early as 1939, classifying them as A, B or C according to the perceived degree of danger. Declared most dangerous were Category A aliens like Vincenzo Beltrone, men who led cultural organizations or were “Pro-Fascist propagandists,” the charge leveled against Beltrone by the Alien Enemy Hearing Board.

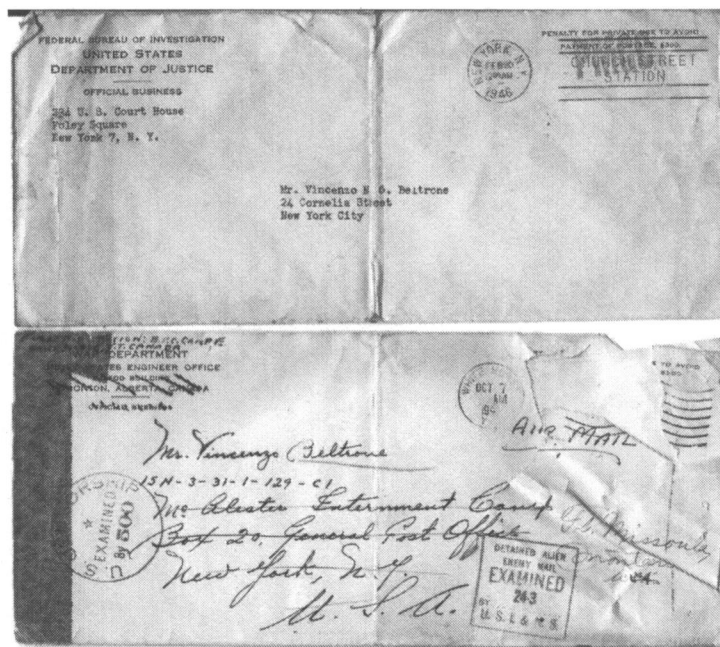
Throughout early December 1941, FBI agents located and arrested suspects on the “ABC List.” Concerned that such arrests be orderly and constitutional, Attorney General Francis Biddle insisted that “arrests were not to occur until the FBI was ready to initiate criminal charges.” Theoretically, the standards were to apply equally to those of

Japanese, German and Italian descent.

Italians, however, seem to have been dismissed as a serious threat. In the fall of 1942, President Roosevelt, who renounced the notion of the Italians as dangerous and referred to them as “a lot of opera singers,” approved Biddle's directive that Italians would no longer be considered “aliens of enemy nationality.”

Unfortunately, this did not help Vincenzo Beltrone, who had already been found guilty of being an alien enemy and who, despite numerous appeals and affidavits regarding his personal loyalty and integrity and a second hearing, spent from December 9, 1941, to May 31, 1945, incarcerated as an enemy of the United States.

Ultimately, the Beltrone story becomes a matter of whom to believe and why. There is Beltrone's own version of his story supported by letters, testimonies of friends and family, and legal documents. There is also the FBI and Justice Department's account that diverges substantially from Beltrone's and is constructed out of a mysterious brew of newspaper clippings, anonymous letters, memoranda from FBI informants, press releases, rumors and overheard conversations.



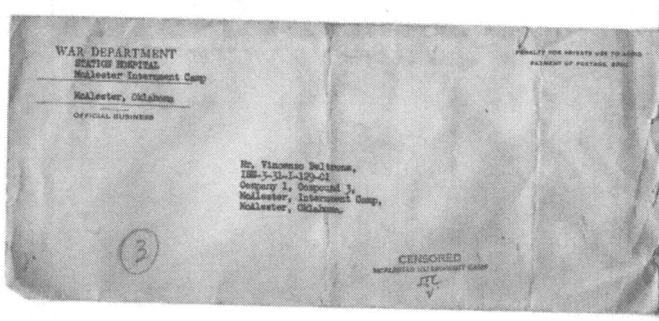
Vincenzo Beltrone was born on August 7, 1895, in Stignano, Calabria, to Giuseppe Beltrone, a 26-year-old farmer, and 23-year-old Ildebranda Cortesi. In 1905, his parents left Stignano for the United States. Beltrone's mother returned to Italy after only one year in America; his father, however, remained in New York City from 1905 to 1923, returning home only to visit his family. In 1907, 12-year-old Beltrone accompanied his father aboard the SS Sannio in Naples. They arrived at the Port of New

York on September 26, 1907.

During his first two years in America, Beltrone attended PS 7 on Chrystie Street and claims to have graduated from DeWitt Clinton High School in 1914. From November to December 1918, Beltrone served in the Coast Artillery of the U. S. Army, in Fort Hamilton, New York. Discharged because of physical disability he would later refer to this one-month stint as his U.S. military service, in an effort to prove his loyalty to America.

The year of Beltrone's arrival (1907) was the high point for Italian immigration to the United States, with 285,731 Italians arriving. By 1910, New York City's Italian population had jumped to 340,765—an increase of more than 100% since 1900. Yet over half of the 3.8 million Italians who landed in the United States between 1899 and 1924 in their flight from poverty returned home to Italy.

Even those who stayed had their doubts. Only 16 of the southern Italian immigrants who chose to remain in the United States between 1899 and 1910 actually became citizens. Beltrone, too, seems to have had his doubts; he did not apply for citizenship until 1937, some 30 years after his arrival in America. His return to Stignano in December 1923 until October 1924 gave Beltrone his first glimpse of Mussolini's Italy. When he returned to the States, he became increasingly involved in the political debates—pro and con—about Mussolini and fascism.



A lot of his time, however, was spent in literary endeavors. In 1927, Beltrone was named “Poet of the New York City School System.” During this same period, he and F.L. McCrudden, another Village writer, founded The Raven Poetry Circle of Greenwich Village, a group of muses whose white-robed members wore ravens emblazoned on their shoulders. The poets took as their motto Beltrone's line: “Ink is the silent partner of remembrance.”

In November 1935, Beltrone returned to Italy for a second visit. He would later contend that he went home for the purpose of settling his father's estate and that while there he was forced to serve in the Italian army. Forced or voluntary, he served with Mussolini's Black Shirts in Somaliland from December 1935 through September 1936.

Beltrone's three war journals written in black composition notebooks reveal much about his inner thoughts and political feelings at

this period. On nearly every page, black ink doodles of his own profile haunt the writing. There is a certain manic quality to the entries, and plenty of politics: "Ethiopia now is tamed and civilized. The rampant nomad will seize no longer the fruits of those who tilled the land with bleeding hands. Victor is emperor and the Duce is lord of all the lands!" Beltrone returned to America in April 1937.

Beltrone was quick to feel the politically changing climate as information-desk guard at the Italian Pavilion in 1939's New York World's Fair: "Those who came to me for information were more concerned about the stand Italy would take in the war than about the facts concerning the building. I replied courteously each time a question of that kind was put to me, that I was not a Bureau to issue War Bulletins."

These essays provided the FBI and the Justice Department with sufficient evidence to convict Beltrone. A summary document prepared for the Alien Enemy Hearing Board on Enemy Alien M68-279 (Vincenzo Beltrone) and signed by Raymond Ickes, assistant United States attorney, concludes: "Subject was apprehended because of his known connection with the fascist paper *Il Grido della Stirpe* and because information has been received of his pro-fascist utterances and tendencies as well as his connections with the Ansonia Club."

There were other incriminating documents to be found in FBI file No. 100-1562, the number assigned to Vincenzo Beltrone. Appended to the extracts from *Il Grido* were several third-party accusations, which were damaging and yet strangely vague.

Beltrone may have been reluctant to express his views to visitors at the Italian pavilion, but elsewhere he seems to have been fairly bold about expressing his opinions.

When FBI agents searched his Greenwich Village apartment on December 23 and 24 of 1941, they found copies of the newspaper *Il Grido della Stirpe* (*The Cry of the Race*), to which Beltrone made weekly contributions.

Beltrone's essays were quite consistent in tone and point of view. They condemned Britain and the Allies, and praised Mussolini and Hitler: "Hitler's olive branch was refused by the British and the French premier. The candid words spoken by Hitler in his speech to the Reichstag remained unanswered....That the war will end with a Germanic victory there is no doubt."

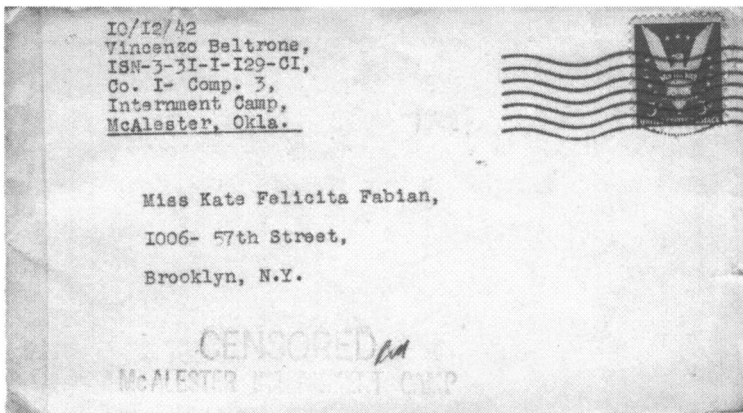
One letter, however, describes in detail a meeting between Beltrone and a young Italian American who did not want to be converted to fascism: "Recently, however, he has been attempting to convert this friend of mine to the fascist cause, without success. As an inducement he has described to her the good times she would have in a so-called 'social' club composed almost entirely of fascists, and the interesting professional people, doctors, lawyers and businessmen, she would meet there. The club is called either the 'Nasonia' or the 'Osonia' Club, and it meets, I believe,

somewhere in Greenwich Village. Beltrone cannot understand why my friend, an American girl whose parents were of Italian birth, should spurn fascism, and when she asked him why, if he liked the fascist regime so well, he didn't return to Italy, he retorted, 'Because I want to bring it here.'"

Within a few months, Beltrone's FBI dossier had grown quite fat, now including four or five letters from informants, surveillance reports from special agents, information from Mayor LaGuardia's office and a press release of the Italian News Service, with a cover memorandum from J. Edgar Hoover recommending "that Beltrone be considered for custodial detention in the event of a national emergency."

From the very beginning of his troubles, Vincenzo Beltrone protested that he was innocent. In a letter to his fiancée, Kate Fabian, dated December 27, 1941, Beltrone writes:

I had to sign to the FBI a written permit for them to go home and look over all of my papers. . . . I could not do otherwise. There is no use to resist those who have the law on their side. Besides, I had no documents of any sort that I wished to hide. My conduct and my life is and was as limpid as the waters of a crystal lake. If I wrote I told the truth and I was not paid by mythical Gods. My greatest God was and is reason.



While awaiting the Alien Enemy Board's decision, Beltrone did his best to console Kate about the hearing. "The last word has not been spoken yet," he wrote. "There is always a voice within a voice that will speak!"

Beltrone was sentenced on February 12, 1942. A day later, he began a series of moves that ultimately took him from Ellis Island to Camp Upton (New York) to Fort George G. Meade in Maryland to McAlester Internment Camp in McAlester, Oklahoma, to Fort Missoula, Montana, and back to Ellis Island once again. On his way to Camp Upton, he warns Kate that his destination may be elsewhere: "It is too early for me to know my role in this martial game. So don't get alarmed."

In a letter to Attorney General Francis Biddle, Beltrone pleaded for a reconsideration of his case: "Since I feel that I am a person with an honorable conduct, thinker and a good observer of the law, I wish that you would give to my appeal your far-reaching and just consideration. I consider myself now a victim of the bellic frenzy that afflicts the world."

But by March 16, Beltrone was settled in Fort Meade, Maryland, as the result of a sudden order. By April, he talked of repatriation to Italy through the efforts of the Legation of Switzerland and its Department of Italian Interests. Musts on his list are the picture of his mother, his espresso coffee machine, his silver, his tool box, his camera and his white suit, all to be packed carefully in a trunk.

"My heart bleeds, my dear Kate, to have to leave this way," he writes her, knowing full well that she and his lawyer disapprove of this plan. A sign of inconsistency, his lawyer claimed; one cannot express the desire for a retrial to prove innocence and at the very same time desire to be repatriated. But Beltrone was convinced that repatriation was his only salvation. As he writes in June, "I am sorry to say that the best way out is to go. I don't simply find it pleasant to have to remain without the bounds of liberty."

There are desperate telegrams: "To Legation of Switzerland. Last Sailing Was Told Repatriation Impossible for Lack Shipping Space Stop Kindly Interest State Department My Desire Repatriate Stop Appreciate Answer Vincenzo Beltrone." Written below the July 14 telegraph, in Beltrone's own hand, is a penciled note: "Undersigned group desirous to know reasons for delayed repatriation third sailing leaves us upset with our respective families. Would like to know reasons for continued delays." As the possibility of repatriation faded, Beltrone more actively pursued contacts through official channels. But there was no change. Throughout 1942 and 1943 Vincenzo Beltrone's alien enemy status remained unchanged despite a flurry of correspondence and requests for a rehearing of his case. Director of Washington's Alien Enemy Control Unit Ennis responded to a request from Beltrone, on June 8, 1943, for a rehearing by suggesting that he write Howard F. Corcoran, the U.S. attorney for the Southern District.

WESTERN UNION

Legation of Switzerland June 1 1942

Cable to Amt. No. Washington, D.C.

Street and No.

Place

Business leave pending sailing on account of health Please interest State Department There is vacancy in Italian group far and Appreciate immediate interest Please reply

Vincenzo Beltrone
1006 57 St

Vincenzo Beltrone

WANT A REPLY?
Western Union has a plan to take your reply to sender's address

WESTERN UNION

RD2146 21 COLLECT FTGEORGEHEAD MD 20 200P

KATE FABIAN 616

DELIVER 1006 57 ST

ASK MANNY ACT CITIZENSHIP PROCEEDINGS CASE NUMBER 342651
'S (WO) SHOULD REQUEST MY PRESENCE IN NEWYORK AUGUST 27
LETTER FOLLOWS

VINCENZO BELTRONE

Ind. Beltrone
K. Deed

342651 S (WO) 27x

One of Beltrone's desperate—but failed—attempts at repatriation

Beltrone followed Ennis' advice, addressing a detailed letter to Corcoran from Fort Missoula, Montana, on July 7, 1943: "I repeat that I have never done acts contrary to the expectations of the American people," Beltrone writes Corcoran. "I have always upheld to the best of my ability the Laws and Institutions of this Country." Beneath this opening statement of loyalty to the United States, Beltrone appends a long string of specific rebuttals:

"In the past World War, I answered the call to arms of the United States. I was later discharged, the Armistice having been signed."

"I entered the petition for citizenship early in 1937 on the status of a soldier. I was given the initial certificate sometime after."

"My last visit to Italy occurred in November 1935. I went there to see my aged mother, to settle property matters with my two brothers Cosimo and Bruno and to try to place on the Italian market some products of the Sorinola Company, an American concern in New York. Upon my arrival in Italy I was called to arms. (I had military service pending for not having

served the compulsory term when I became of 'military age.') I was at the time residing here and could not do so. I was sent with the Army to Ethiopia on January 3 and returned to Italy in September of the same year, 1936."

Beltrone goes on to explain that since 1937 he had belonged to two organizations, The Italian-American Forum and the Ansonia Club, both "non-political. Their purposes were social and educational. They were typically American, both in character and scope. My membership in the first and later in the second had ceased long before, the time of my arrest. To no other organization, local or foreign, have I belonged."

Here as elsewhere, Beltrone describes his journalistic activities as harmless. "I have written articles for a weekly newspaper known as *Il Grido della Stirpe* published in New York. I received no pay for said articles," he explains and goes on to add that "the articles were analytical of the situation that was brooding in Europe and were not political. I have written same in good faith without the intention of political colorings and in the true spirit of Freedom of the Press. I had no other connection with the administration of the newspaper."

His plea to Corcoran echoes his earlier plea to Biddle: "Having lived here most of my conscious life, it is logical and natural that my love for this country is not the product of the moment but has its roots in my long association with things American. I have considered myself a participant in the goings-on and the life of the Nation." Finally, Beltrone concludes that "I can assure you that an error has been committed with my arrest. I am asking you now to kindly undo that error."

Three weeks later, Ennis acknowledged receipt of the letter to Corcoran together with supporting materials. A familiar refrain closes the note: "You will be notified if any change can be made in your status as an internee."

Still, Beltrone persisted in battling the bureaucrats. "I'm of the opinion that if the spirit of Freedom of the Press were to be granted to me, I'd be liberated...." Beltrone writes U.S. District Attorney James McNally. Then, he cites his good behavior and his efforts to "remain in harmony with those over me. At McAlester, Oklahoma, I have painted several murals of American life in the Officers' Hall and also the Post's Chapel. I wish to point out here that I am the only one left of all those arrested on the 8th of December 1941 in New York and Boroughs. I cannot understand the reasons that have so far held my case back from its natural solution. I do not think, Honorable McNally, that my case differs from theirs."

Beltrone's perception of his model behavior at the McAlester Internment Camp was not shared by those who evaluated him. A conduct report submitted on March 5, 1943, lists his character as "unfavorable" and says that he expressed views which were anti-U.S. and pro-Axis, and reacted negatively to any news favorable to the United States. On the back of the report signed by Army Intelligence Officer Captain J.T. Carlisle,

Carlisle has added: "Beltrone is an outspoken fascist, belonging to the Membrini, Gloria, Lucchesi, Piccione, Grosso group."

Beneath these words, in the same hand, is an even more damaging entry: "His statements are caustic, and one of the internees reported to this officer that he attempted to set fire to one of the barracks. We have no proof of this. J. T. C."

A second report on Beltrone from Fort Missoula dated September 1943 embellishes Beltrone's negative reputation by giving him two unfavorable checks for his mental condition and the character of his associates. This time the explanatory remarks on the back of the report read: "Despondent at times that he can't find outlet for his painting talents. Keeps company with Gloria, Membrini & Santucci."

Another letter from Mr. Forman, chief of the Detention Section, from Ellis Island, enclosed a conduct report, signed by a Mr. Lyons, Immigrant Inspector, on Sept. 8, 1944. Lyons' report includes a question-and-answer interview regarding Beltrone's present political attitudes. The questions are sharp and very direct:

Question: "What is your opinion of Mussolini?"

Answer: "You mean as a man—a government?"

Question: "As a man and as the head of the Fascist government of Italy."

Answer: "Well, I believe that he had his flurry, as your own newspapers exulted him, and extinguished itself."

Question: "Do you believe Italy was justified in its invasion of Ethiopia?"

Answer: "Well, apparently—they said they needed expansion—a place in the sun. That was the cry of 44 million people."

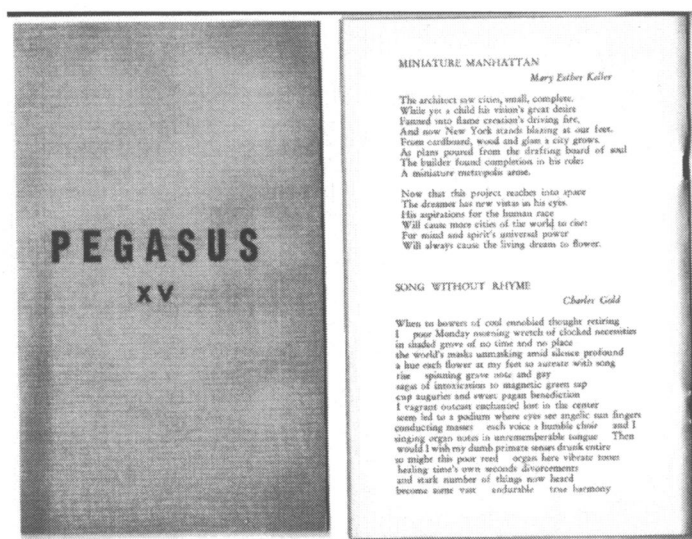
Lyons concluded that Beltrone would not be a good risk for parole. Foreman concurred with Lyons' analysis.

Beltrone tried another approach, filing a petition for a writ of habeas corpus, which alleged that in view of Italy's co-belligerency with the United States, Italian nationals were not alien enemies. But Ennis ruled that since the state of war with Italy had not been terminated by a treaty of peace, Beltrone should remain interned.

Finally, on May 9, 1945, Vincenzo Beltrone was paroled from detention on Ellis Island. Nearly three and one-half years after his arrest, Beltrone was freed. He was not, however, declared innocent. The Italians were no longer a threat and Beltrone as an Italian alien was no longer considered dangerous. In fact, his parole followed a memo to Arnold B. Du Bois regarding all of the Italian internees: "As a result of the German military surrender in Italy, the Attorney General on May 4, 1945, approved the release from internment of the remaining Italian internees." Beltrone just couldn't be interned any longer; so he was released. Included in the Justice Department memos from this period are two pages with the heading "Interned Italians." But the only name on the two pages that can be read is Vincenzo Beltrone. The other names—20 or more of them—

have been blacked out.

Vincenzo Beltrone and Kate Fabian were married on May 6, 1945. The following fall, still dogged in his determination, Beltrone petitioned for naturalization, but his citizenship was denied on the grounds of his having been interned as an alien enemy. He was never to become a citizen, dying five years later in 1950 at the age of 55.



Kate Fabian Beltrone dedicated the next 15 years of her life to an effort to clear his name. When she died in 1964, his letters, his journals, his poetry, his fiction, his immigration papers, all neatly organized in pink satin ribbons, were packed away in cartons and stored in an Upstate New York basement.

There were letters to publishers. There were letters from friends. There were volumes of *Pegasus*, the poetry magazine on which Kate Fabian Beltrone served as a member of the editorial board. There were poems by Beltrone published in New York and in Kansas City. There was his crumpled Alien Enemy Registration card, his father's passport and a steel block engraving of Vincenzo looking devastatingly handsome, his black hair slicked back, his strong profile bearing a keen resemblance to actor Robert De Niro.

Vincenzo Beltrone, Alien Enemy M68-279, prisoner of the U. S. government from 1941-1945—a man undone by words.